Rajasthan, where he was hiding in disguise. But the demolition? Officials ascribed that to unauthorised construction. Not many bought that, for Mansa was seething with mob fury. Jhota's supporters had bulldozed Ashwani's shop, then set it on fire. Amidst slogans demanding "Yogi Adityanath-type" justice, they had to be stopped from marching on Ashwani's house.

EVERYONE PASSES TO HIM

Unauthorised construction? A very plausible reading is that someone quickly authorised the construction of an official line that could supply an official demolition. The anger that needed to be sated owed to a narrative that seems straightforward: that Jhota was confronting Ashwani as he sold drugs to an elderly man, livestreaming the act, when the gunshots rang in an unexpected climax. A small complication hangs as a prequel to this, though. The killing, says Bathinda Range DIG Harjeet Singh, may have stemmed from personal enmity.

The two men have a history. In 2023, Jhota and his men allegedly paraded Ashwani through a market garlanded with shoes, accusing him of selling banned capsules. Police registered a case on Jhota's complaint, but also booked Jhota for taking the law into his own hands. Like a slugger in the ring, Jhota liked to confront suspected drug-sellers on camera—his videos brought a following as well as accusations of vigilantism. He also had several criminal cases against him.

But nuances died on the spot amidst spiralling outrage. Protesters gathered outside the mortuary, and Jhota's family refused to cremate him until its demands were met. His father, ex-serviceman Bhim Singh, accused the government of failing to curb the drug trade. A joint action committee called a state-wide bandh to demand a CBI probe, dismissal of the police chief, and Mann's scalp.

Opposition leaders joined in soon enough. Those delivering rhetorical punches to Mann included ex-state Congress chief Amrinder Singh Raja Warring, ex-BJP state chief Sunil Jakhar, his successor Kewal Singh Dhillon and, in a twist the commentariat may relish, Akali Dal chief Sukhbir Badal. Not long ago, the shoe was on the other foot.

Mansa lies in Malwa, Punjab's largest electoral region, with 69 of its 117 assembly seats. AAP won 66 of them in 2022. Tackling drugs was a key campaign promise, and observers give a mixed verdict on its fulfilment. Going in its favour is a demonstrative blur: action against police-mafia nexuses, property seizures, high conviction rates, high-profile targets. But the record also shows missed deadlines, a mutating trade that has taken to drone-based delivery at the border, a Supreme Court censure, and peril for activists. Mann's luck that a murder ticks that last box, putting a bullet-hole or two through his narrative just months before an election. ■

Takeaways

- **Parvinder Singh Jhota, anti-drug activist and social media influencer, killed in Mansa; chemist arrested**
- **Jhota accosted suspects in the act of peddling, live-streaming his act—acquiring a vigilante's profile**
- **The murder feeds straight into pre-poll air, Opposition says AAP unable to tame drug trade**

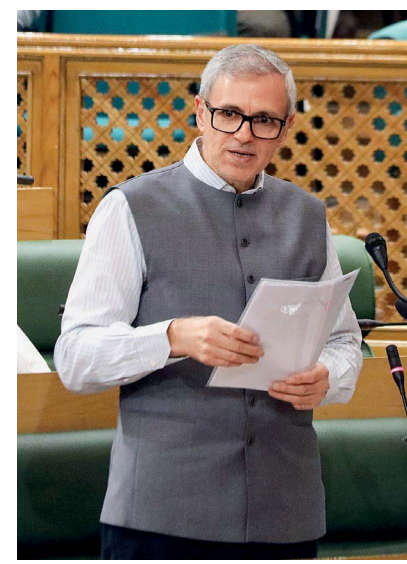
▶ JAMMU AND KASHMIR

The State of Being a Non-State

Omar steers a statehood resolution, the second one in two years. It's a reminder as well as renewal of oath

By **Ishfaq Tantry**

IT WAS A SMALL SET PIECE OF LEGISLATIVE THEATRE, meant as much for the acoustics in the hall as the desire for the voice to carry to New Delhi. No one would object if it does, of course. Overcoming its status diminution is an idea that carries broad consensus in Jammu and Kashmir. So, on September 28, when the assembly adopted a resolution seeking the "immediate and urgent restoration of full statehood", it wasn't chafing against anyone's politics. Ever since 2019, when



ANI

ON THE MOVE Omar Abdullah at the J&K assembly in Srinagar, Sept. 25